

An additional consideration is what to do when one partner earns more money. If you earn less but are asked to equally contribute to the household bills, this will leave less money for your own needs. Is this fair? If you decide to pay in proportion to your income contribution, how do you decide which bills you are responsible for? There are no easy answers; each couple needs to figure out these arrangements on their own.

A further complication occurs when the woman earns more. Among married couples, 25 percent of wives earn more than their husbands, according to the U.S. Census Bureau's 2005 data. But for many men and women, they have been socialized to believe that the man should be the primary wage earner. Even though the wage gap has been shrinking and the majority of women are in the workforce, many households would still feel it was a matter of concern if a wife earned more than her husband.

All of these issues are not easy ones to resolve but they are crucial. The following checklist for couples will help to make sure you address these and other important questions.

We have:

- ☐ Discussed our financial attitudes and values
- ☐ Investigated each other's income and employment patterns
- ☐ Discussed each other's credit history
- ☐ Read through each other's health, automobile, and life insurance plans
- ☐ Developed separate time lines for what we hope to accomplish in the next year, three years, longer
- ☐ Put together a budget we both believe in
- ☐ Agreed to distribution of payment responsibilities
- ☐ Made decisions about joint or separate accounts

Without addressing these issues, couples will continue to face financial difficulties.

